

J P MOVEMENT

clearly anti-Congress, striving to establish the rule of law. The ideology of the movement developed while dealing with the Naxalites from 1969 onwards. He felt that Vinoba Bhave's Bhoodan Movement had failed to bring about change and had accepted the Congress misrule. The answer to this was a non-violent struggle, by the people, for a total revolution where Narayan would fight against the abuse of democratic institutions.

The origins of the movement also lay in the Nav Nirman Movement of the youth in Gujarat in 1973-74, which was directed against corruption in the Congress government led by Chimanbhai Patel, with a demand for the government to be dismissed and the assembly dissolved. Simultaneously, of far greater significance, were the events in Bihar in March 1974, where the student's union sought the resignation of chief minister Abdul Gaffur and the dissolution of the assembly. Narayan was requested to provide leadership. He agreed on the condition that the protesters would not use violence. On April 9, 1974, he led a silent protest in Patna. The protestors had covered their mouths and many had their hands tied. Despite Narayan's intermittent ill health, protests continued with people demanding that the Congress government adhere to standards of public conduct and reform electoral laws. In June, he led a procession, with truck loads of petitions addressed to the Bihar governor, asking him to dissolve the assembly. When the demonstrators were returning to Gandhi Maidan, they were fired upon by the Indira brigade. Narayan persuaded the crowd against resorting to violence, saying: "Friends, this is a total revolution. This is not a movement merely for the dissolution of the assembly. We have to go far, very far..." It was at that moment that the youth of the Bihar Action Committee conferred on him the title Loknayak.

By the end of the year, Narayan had assumed the leadership of the National Coordination Committee to paralyse the Central government. On November 4, he led a peaceful procession in Patna, which was stopped by over 60,000 police and army men. The police action resulted in Narayan suffering severe injuries. It was an act of barbarism that remains etched in public memory till date.

Some of the worst actions of the Congress soon came to the forefront. Railway minister L.N. Mishra was killed in a bomb explosion in Bihar on January 1, 1975. Opposition leaders



FOLLOWING THE MAHATMA: Narayan celebrates Gandhi's birthday in Patna

charged the Congress, and Indira Gandhi herself, of having engineered the assassination, while she accused Narayan and his followers of this. In this surcharged atmosphere, the Allahabad High Court said Indira Gandhi could not remain in office and nullified her election on grounds of electoral malpractice. Emergency was declared on June 26 and in a pre-dawn sweep, Narayan and other leaders were arrested and the press censored. Twenty months of opposition to the Emergency saw the movement spreading to academic institutions, with common people joining in along with the administrators. The entire Opposition was united.

After the Emergency in 1977, the Janata Party came to power. Having challenged the abuse of power, Narayan himself turned away from it. In an interview to Yashwant Sinha, then principal secretary, Janata government in Bihar, Narayan said he hoped the movement and its people would stay together. His expectation, "Power is such a glue that it binds together", was clearly belied when cracks appeared in the government and the party, first in Bihar, and then subsequently at the national level.

More than 30 years after the movement, two significant issues still talked about are—the quality of leaders it generated, and the ease with which many student leaders, such as, Subodh Kant Sahay and Lalu Prasad Yadav, changed political affiliation.

The author teaches political science at Gargi College, Delhi University

INDIRA GANDHI, prime minister, 1976

"A conspiracy has been brewing ever since I began progressive measures."